

Banff, Yoho → Jasper Loop

4 BASE CAMPS

AUG 18 - 27, 2026 · YYC ROUND TRIP

BASE 01

Canmore, AB

Aug 18 - 21

3 Nights

Moraine · Louise ·
Johnston · Banff
viewpoints

BASE 02

Golden, BC

Aug 21 - 23

2 Nights

Emerald · Takakkaw ·
Wapta · Golden
Skybridge

BASE 03

Valemount, BC

Aug 23 - 26

3 Nights

Mount Robson · Maligne
· Pyramid · Jasper
viewpoints

BASE 04

Calgary, AB

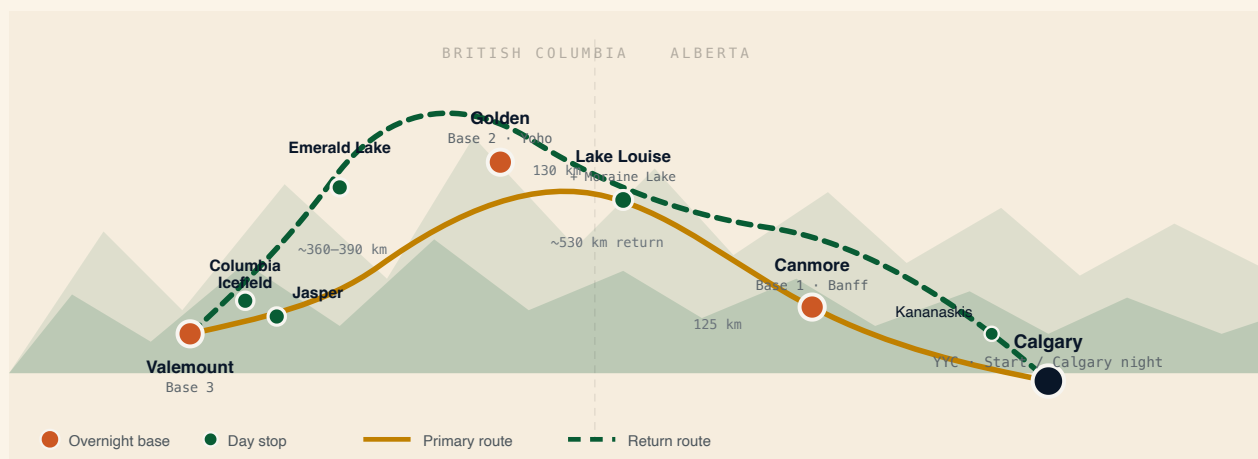
Aug 26 - 27

1 Night

Positioning night · easy
YYC rental return · fly
out rested

THE ROUTE

Calgary → Canmore → Golden → Valemount → Calgary



LEG	KM	EST. TIME	HIGHWAY
Calgary YYC → Canmore	125 km	~1.5 hr	Hwy 2 N → Trans-Canada Hwy 1 W
Canmore → Golden	130 km	1.5–2.5 hr + stops	Hwy 1 W through Lake Louise and Kicking Horse Pass
Golden → Valemount	~360–390 km	5–6 hr + stops	Hwy 1 E → Icefields Parkway / Hwy 93 N → Jasper → Hwy 16 W
Valemount ↔ Jasper	120 km each way	~1.5 hr each way	Yellowhead Hwy 16 through Mount Robson
Valemount → Calgary, AB	~530 km	6.5–7.5 hr + stops	Hwy 16 E → Hwy 93 S → Hwy 1 E → Hwy 2 S
Calgary hotel → YYC	5–20 km	10–25 min	Calgary local roads
Total trip driving	~1,300+ km	~18–22 hr	Includes scenic transfer days, Jasper day trip driving, and the Calgary return



TUESDAY, AUGUST 18, 2026

Calgary Arrival → Canmore

125 km • ~1.5 hr • Return rental YYC → YYC

● **Fly into Calgary YYC** Morning

Collect luggage and pick up the SUV rental at YYC. This is now a round-trip rental, so confirm the Calgary return location and keep the reservation simple.

● **Calgary grocery stop** ~30 min

Stock snacks, breakfast items, water, sunscreen, and trail food before heading west. Grocery options are easy in Canmore, but Calgary is the lowest-friction first stop.

● **Drive to Canmore** Afternoon

Take Hwy 2 north, then Trans-Canada Hwy 1 west. The first big mountain reveal comes as the Bow Valley opens near Canmore.

- **Check into Canmore Airbnb** Evening

Settle into the first base. Walk Main Street, confirm shuttle and Pursuit reservations, and keep the first night easy.

BOOK BEFORE YOU GO

Prioritize Moraine Lake shuttle, Maligne Lake Cruise, Columbia Icefield, Banff Gondola, and the Canmore, Golden, Valemount, and Calgary lodging details. If your Pursuit package makes you choose between Lake Minnewanka and Maligne, choose Maligne.

DAY

2

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 19, 2026

Lake Louise + Moraine Lake

Canmore base • shuttle day • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Lake Louise Park & Ride** Early morning

Drive to the Lake Louise Ski Resort Park & Ride and check in for your reserved Parks Canada shuttle. Use the connector to see both Lake Louise and Moraine Lake in one day.

- **Moraine Lake — Rockpile viewpoint** Morning

Start with the Valley of Ten Peaks while light is clean and crowds are lower. Rockpile is the essential short walk; canoe rentals are optional if the line is reasonable.

- **Lake Louise lakeshore or Tea House hike** Midday

For a lighter day, walk the lakeshore to Victoria Glacier views and keep time for a proper lunch. For stronger hikers, Lake Agnes Tea House is the best upgrade.

- **Return to Canmore without adding another major stop** Late afternoon

Protect this as the biggest lake day of the Banff section. Save Johnston Canyon for tomorrow, when it can be done early and unrushed.

MORAINE LAKE LOGISTICS

Personal vehicles are not permitted on Moraine Lake Road. Use Parks Canada shuttle, Roam transit, or a licensed commercial operator; reserve early and set an alarm for released seats.

THURSDAY, AUGUST 20, 2026

DAY

3

Johnston Canyon + Banff Viewpoints

Local Banff loop • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Johnston Canyon Lower + Upper Falls** Early morning

Go early while parking and catwalks are calmer. This is the best easy waterfall walk in the Banff section and fits better here than after the Lake Louise shuttle day.

- **Banff Avenue + Bow Falls** Midday

Lunch in Banff, then walk to Bow Falls for an easy river viewpoint. Add Surprise Corner or the Fairmont viewpoint if the group wants one more quick photo stop.

- **Banff Gondola — Sulphur Mountain** Afternoon • Pursuit Pass

Ride to the summit boardwalk for the cleanest panoramic view of the Bow Valley. A later slot also avoids forcing a rushed morning after the lake day.

- **Lake Minnewanka scenic drive if energy is good** Optional

Use the cruise only if it is included and the timing is easy. Otherwise Two Jack Lake and the Lake Minnewanka shoreline are a lower-pressure add-on.

- **Pack for Yoho / Golden** Evening

Tomorrow crosses the Continental Divide. Confirm Golden Airbnb check-in and make sure fuel, snacks, and offline maps are set.

DAY

4

FRIDAY, AUGUST 21, 2026

Canmore → Golden

130 km • 1.5-2.5 hr + Yoho stops

- **Scenic drive over Kicking Horse Pass** Morning

Leave Canmore after breakfast and head west past Lake Louise into Yoho. The drive is short enough to make the transfer day feel like sightseeing, not a slog.

- **Spiral Tunnels viewpoint** Quick stop

Classic railway engineering stop on the Trans-Canada. Worth a short pullout if visibility is good and timing is easy.

- **Takakkaw Falls** Midday • seasonal road

Make this the transfer-day anchor while you are already passing through Yoho. The road is seasonal and winding, so skip it if conditions or timing are poor.

- **Natural Bridge + Emerald Lake preview** Afternoon

Natural Bridge is a fast, high-value stop. If the group still has energy, use Emerald Lake as a first look and save the slower shoreline time for tomorrow.

- **Check into Golden Airbnb** Evening

Golden gives you the right mix of lodging, food options, and access to Yoho. Keep dinner local and avoid adding another long detour.



SATURDAY, AUGUST 22, 2026

Yoho National Park

Golden base • 2-3 hr total driving

- **Emerald Lake slow morning** Morning

Walk part of the shoreline before the day fills in, rent canoes if conditions are calm, and treat this as the Yoho anchor rather than a quick photo stop.

- **Natural Bridge or Iceline trail segment** Midday

Keep the default comfortable with Natural Bridge, lunch, and short walks. If the group wants a real hiking day, replace the easier stops with a planned Iceline segment.

- **Wapta Falls + optional Golden Skybridge** Afternoon

Wapta Falls is the nature-forward pick and deserves priority. Golden Skybridge is the paid attraction option if the group wants something structured before dinner.

- **Early night before the northbound transfer** Evening

Tomorrow is a long scenic drive to Valemount. Fuel up, pack lunch, and keep the Icefields Parkway stops selective.

WHY GOLDEN WORKS

Golden is the efficient Yoho base: it keeps Emerald Lake, Natural Bridge, Takakkaw Falls, Wapta Falls, and dinner options close without forcing another Banff hotel move.



SUNDAY, AUGUST 23, 2026

Golden → Valemount

Icefields Parkway • viewpoint stops only • 6+ hr road day

- **Leave Golden early and keep stops disciplined** Morning

This is not a short transfer. Drive back through Lake Louise, turn north onto the Icefields Parkway, and treat the road itself as the main experience.

- **Bow Lake + Peyto Lake viewpoints** Quick stops

Use these as high-value, low-time stops. Bow Lake is an easy shoreline pause; Peyto is the quick overlook. Avoid adding long hikes today.

- **Athabasca Falls before Jasper** Afternoon

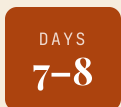
Make this the waterfall priority if timing is good. Skip Sunwapta or the Columbia Icefield tour today so the group is not arriving in Valemount exhausted.

- **Jasper supply stop, then Valemount Airbnb** Evening

Pick up groceries or dinner in Jasper before continuing west on Hwy 16. Valemount check-in is 4pm, but this road day will likely arrive later.

VALEMOUNT BASE REALITY CHECK

Valemount is a workable Jasper access base, but not a Jasper town stay. Budget about 1.5 hours each way to Jasper before adding Maligne Lake, Pyramid Lake, or town activities.



MONDAY-TUESDAY, AUGUST 24-25, 2026

Mount Robson + One Strong Jasper Day

Valemount base • one local day, one Jasper day

AUG 24 — MOUNT ROBSON / VALEMOUNT

- **Mount Robson viewpoint + visitor area**

Morning

AUG 25 — JASPER / MALIGNE ROAD

- **Medicine Lake viewpoint** Morning

Leave Valemount early and drive through Jasper to Maligne Road. Medicine Lake is the

Use the local advantage of Valemount instead of driving back to Jasper immediately. If the peak is clear, this is one of the most memorable mountain views of the trip.

- **Kinney Lake trail or easier local recovery**

Half day

For active travelers, hike the lower Berg Lake Trail toward Kinney Lake as conditions allow. For a softer day, keep it to Robson viewpoints, Valemount food, laundry, and recovery.

- **Prepare for Jasper day**

Evening

Book the earliest practical Maligne Lake Cruise window and pack food, layers, and fuel so tomorrow's longer out-and-back feels intentional.

best low-effort stop before continuing to Maligne Lake.

- **Maligne Lake Cruise**

Book ahead · Pursuit Pass option

Use this as the Jasper anchor. Spirit Island is the postcard view, and it is worth building the day around one firm reservation.

- **Pyramid Lake + Jasper town dinner**

Late day

If timing allows, add Pyramid Island before dinner in Jasper. Skip extra attractions if the group is tired; the Valemount return still adds about 1.5 hours.

NORTHERN ROCKIES BASE

Valemount keeps Mount Robson close and gives the group a dedicated Jasper day for Maligne Lake, Pyramid Lake, and town time.

DAY

9

WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 26, 2026

Valemount → Calgary

~530 km · long road day · no flight pressure

- **Checkout from Valemount**

By 10am

Make this the long travel day instead of departure day. Check DriveBC and 511 Alberta before leaving, then head east through Mount Robson and Jasper.

- **Columbia Icefield Adventure + Skywalk**

Book ahead · Pursuit Pass

This fits better on the return day than the Golden-to-Valemount transfer. Book a late-morning or midday slot, then keep the rest of the drive simple.

- **Check into Calgary hotel**

Evening

Stay in Calgary with easy access to YYC tomorrow. This removes the stressful mountain drive from flight day and makes the rental return straightforward.

WHY THIS WORKS BETTER

The long Valemount-to-Calgary drive still exists, but this is the better day for Columbia Icefield because there is no flight timing behind it. Aug 27 stays a short local transfer.

DAY

10

THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2026

Calgary → Fly Out

10-25 min local transfer • Return SUV at YYC

- **Slow morning near YYC** Flight dependent

Breakfast, final packing, and a short local drive. No mountain highway pressure on departure day.

- **Return SUV at Calgary YYC** Per flight schedule

Allow the normal airport buffer for rental return, bag drop, and security. The route is now simple enough for morning, midday, or evening flights.

DEPARTURE DAY

This is now intentionally boring: short drive, rental return, airport. That is the point.

QUICK REFERENCE

Highlights + Planning Reference

Moraine Lake

Valley of Ten Peaks, accessed by shuttle or licensed operator. This is the most important reservation in the Banff portion.

Lake Louise

Pair the lakeshore with Moraine Lake, or upgrade to Lake Agnes Tea House if the group wants a moderate hike.

Emerald Lake

The Yoho anchor. Less urban than Banff, easier to linger, and a strong reason to keep the Golden base.

Takakkaw Falls

High-impact waterfall stop in Yoho. Best as a transfer-day anchor if the seasonal road is open.

Columbia Icefield

Best saved for the Valemount-to-Calgary return day. It is too much to combine with every northbound viewpoint and a Valemount arrival.

Maligne Lake + Mount Robson

Treat Maligne as one intentional Jasper day and Mount Robson as the local Valemount payoff. That keeps the northern base worthwhile.

PARK ADMISSION

Your dates fall inside Parks Canada's 2026 free-admission window, but shuttle tickets, paid parking, tours, and attraction reservations still need to be booked separately.

JASPER CLOSURES

Do not build the plan around Maligne Canyon or Edith Cavell for 2026. Keep Jasper flexible and confirm road/trail status close to travel.

AUGUST WEATHER + PACKING

Warm days, cool nights, fast weather changes. Pack shell jackets, layers, sunscreen, water bottles, bug spray, and footwear that can handle wet trails.

DRIVING + FUEL NOTES

Top off in Canmore, Golden, Jasper, and Valemount. Keep offline maps for Yoho, Icefields Parkway, Hwy 16, Maligne Road, and the Aug 26 Valemount-to-Calgary return.

SHARED TRIP MAP

Use the group Google My Maps for saved stops, route context, and day-by-day planning: [open the Rockies trip map](#).